

Grus japonensis

Red-crowned crane



Length 5 ft (1.5 m)
Weight 15–26 lb (7–12 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Endangered

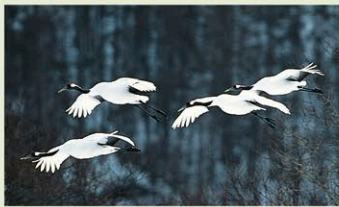
Location E. Asia



With its intricate courtship dances and lifelong partnerships, this elegant bird has long been a symbol of happiness and good luck. The heaviest member



CONSERVATION



The total population of red-crowned cranes stands at about 2,750 birds. About 1,000 of these live in Japan—a spectacular increase from the 1920s, when numbers dropped to just 20. However, the species is still in danger, particularly during its long migration flights.

of the crane family, it is mainly white, with black flight feathers and a black face and neck. Large flocks congregate on feeding grounds in winter, but in the breeding season, pairs of birds establish territories, defending them vigorously against other cranes.

COURTING DANCES

During courtship, the red-crowned crane performs elaborate dances involving head bobbing, bowing, pirouettes, jumping, and tossing material in the air.

enable it to extract snails from their shells with ease. Breeding pairs often stay together year after year, and the male defends the nest by charging intruders, fighting with its feet, and uttering an unearthly, mournful call.



slender, sharp bill

Aramus guarauna

Limpkin



Length 22–28 in (56–71 cm)
Weight 2¼–3¼ lb (1–1.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern

Location S.E. USA (Florida), Central and South America



An ibislike bird with a striking brown and white spangled neck, the limpkin has a long, slender bill that is sharpened and slightly twisted at its tip—features that

Crex crex

Corn crake



Length 10½–12 in (27–30 cm)
Weight 4–7 oz (125–200 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern

Location Europe, W. to C. Asia, S.E. Africa



Heard far more easily than seen, this cryptically colored bird has a loud and rasping, 2-syllable call, which the male makes both to advertise its territory and to attract females. The call becomes a growling, piglike squeal before mating, or during encounters with other males. The corn crake is declining in many parts of its range as a direct result of changes in farming

practices and because the damp pastures it inhabits are increasingly drained and plowed.



Balearica regulorum

Gray-crowned crane



Length 3¼–3½ ft (1–1.1 m)
Weight 6½–8¼ lb (3–4 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Endangered

Location E. and southern Africa



Gray-crowned cranes are easily identified by their golden crests, or “crowns,” and by their ability to perch in trees—something that other cranes cannot do. Found in both marshland and cultivated

fields, this bird has a relatively short, versatile bill, unlike more aquatic cranes. It stamps its feet while foraging to flush out potential prey, and travels with large mammals to feed on the insects frightened by their movement. Another species, the black crowned crane, occurs in tropical Africa.



red throat wattle

gray plumage

well-developed hind toe for perching

Psophia crepitans

Gray-winged trumpeter



Length 20 in (50 cm)
Weight 2¼–3¼ lb (1–1.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Near threatened

Location N. South America



This black, humpbacked bird is one of 3 species in the trumpeter family, all found in South America. Small groups

of 6–8 live on the forest floor, bathing and roosting together, and foraging for the fallen fruit that are their main food. They use a variety of calls, some loud and trumpeting, to warn of danger, beg for food, mark territory, and threaten intruders. Unusually for birds, several males mate with one female.



Gallinula chloropus

Common moorhen



Length 12–15 in (30–38 cm)
Weight 6–18 oz (175–500 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

Location Worldwide except Australia



The moorhen is one of the world’s most widespread freshwater birds. A member of the rail family, it has distinctive white markings along the flanks and a conspicuous red “shield” and yellow-tipped red bill. Although not as shy as other rails, and often seen moving in the open, if threatened, the common moorhen will flee into dense cover.



white flank markings

Porphyrio porphyrio

Western swamphen

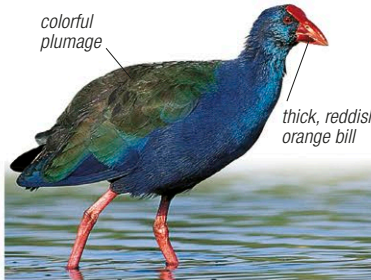


Length 15–20 in (38–50 cm)
Weight 18–46 oz (500–1,300 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern

Location S. Europe, W., S., and S.E. Asia, Australia, Africa



One of the biggest members of the rail family—almost as big as a chicken—the western swamphen is a powerful, robustly built bird with purple and black plumage, a reddish orange bill, and long legs and toes. It feeds on all manner of vegetation, pulling it up with its bill, as well as on aquatic and terrestrial invertebrates. It will also eat the eggs and young of other waterbirds, climbing if necessary to reach the nest.



colorful plumage

thick, reddish orange bill